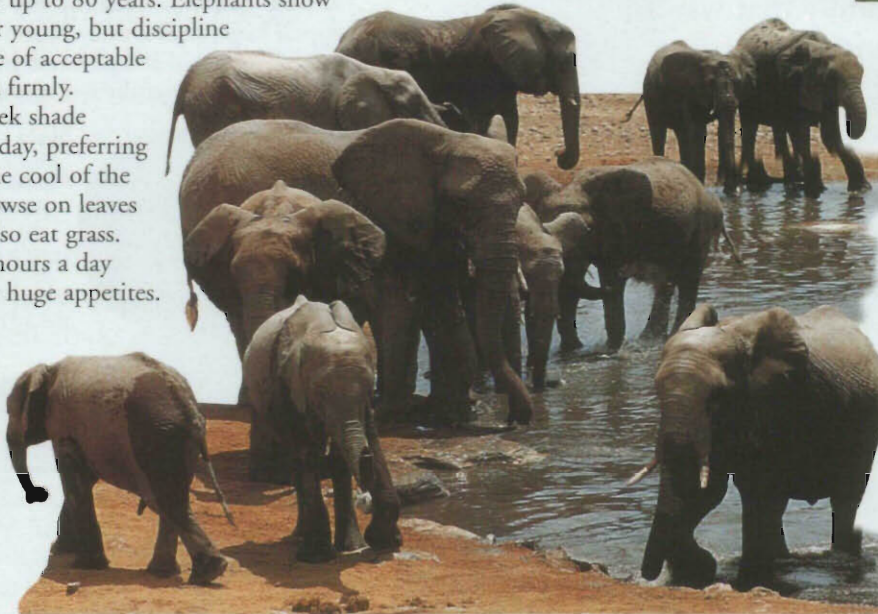


## Family group

The elephant's social organization is based upon a group of 10–12 females and their calves, led by a mature female. Harmonious relationships often develop between individual members of the group. Friendships can last for decades as elephants often live for up to 80 years. Elephants show great affection for their young, but discipline is strong, and any lapse of acceptable behaviour is dealt with firmly. Family groups often seek shade during the heat of the day, preferring to feed and drink in the cool of the evening. Elephants browse on leaves and shoots, but they also eat grass. They spend about 18 hours a day feeding, to satisfy their huge appetites.

### Matriarch

Leadership of the family unit rests with the oldest and most experienced female, the matriarch, who is usually the mother or grandmother of the whole group. Each member of the group knows its position in the hierarchy and respects matriarchal authority without question.



### Herd gathering

Separate family groups associate closely with each other. They often live only a few hundred metres apart, constantly coming together and drifting apart again. Occasionally, many family groups congregate in an exceptionally large herd of more than a thousand animals.

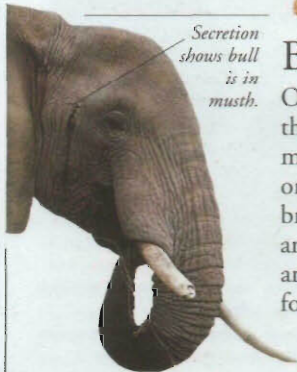


### Young

Females normally conceive every four years and give birth to a single calf after 22 months' gestation. This is the longest gestation period of any animal. The newborn calf stands about 84 cm (33 in) high. Other calves from previous matings remain with their mother after the new calf is born. The older calves help to take care of their younger siblings.

### Water holes

Elephants like to drink every day. They also enjoy bathing and spraying themselves with water. As the dry season advances, food and water become scarce, and they may have to walk up to 80 km (50 miles) between watering and feeding grounds. They also dig holes in some riverbeds to reach water below the surface, thereby providing water for other animals.



Secretion shows bull is in musth.

## Bulls

Only immature bull calves are allowed in the family group; as soon as the bulls reach maturity they are expelled. They live alone or in small bachelor groups. Mature bulls briefly rejoin the herd when any of the cows are ready for mating.

### Fighting

Young bulls often have mock battles to test each other's strength. They are usually harmless affairs where they clash tusks and grapple with each other's trunks. Older bulls, especially those in musth, may sometimes fight in defence of territory or to establish dominance.



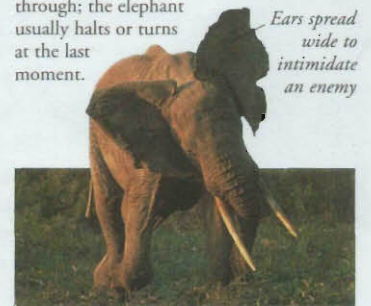
Young bulls sparring

### Musth

By 25 years of age, bulls come into musth once a year. Musth is a period of aggressive behaviour where a bull picks fights with other bulls searching for a female ready to mate. A thick secretion from the temporal gland indicates he is in musth.

### Threat displays

Differences between elephants are generally resolved peacefully. Displeasure is indicated by means of a threat display. This involves head-shaking, ear-spreading, trunk-twirling, and foot-shuffling. If this fails to deter, the elephant may make a full-scale charge. This is a rare event where the elephant covers ground at rapid speed, with its trunk raised and ears outstretched, while trumpeting furiously. Threat charges are rarely carried through; the elephant usually halts or turns at the last moment.



Ears spread wide to intimidate an enemy

## Communication

Touch is an important way of communicating in elephant society. When elephants meet, they greet each other by entwining trunks and touching each other's face and body. At rest, they often stand together, head to head. If a young calf misbehaves, its mother may actually use her trunk to smack it. When a calf is frightened, other elephants help to calm it by standing close, and caressing it with their trunks.

Elephants standing face to face and touching each other's heads and trunks.



### Rumbling

Elephants maintain contact by means of rumbling sounds from the throat, back of the nose, and trunk. A sudden cessation of rumbling warns the herd of possible danger. Elephants are also capable of communicating over substantial distances, by low-frequency sounds which humans cannot hear.



## AFRICAN ELEPHANT

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Loxodonta africana*

ORDER Proboscidea

FAMILY Elephantidae

DISTRIBUTION Africa south of the Sahara

HABITAT Open savannahs and woodlands

DIET Grasses, leaves, shoots, twigs, and other browse

SIZE Height at shoulder: 4 m (13 ft); weight: 6.1 tonnes (6 tons)

LIFESPAN 70–80 years

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